

THE FEASTS OF JEHOVAH

Otter Creek Assembly of God

5/2004

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Text: Leviticus 23:1-5

Introduction;

God commanded his people after they came out of Egypt to hold meetings with him three times per year. They were called feasts. Yet they were mostly convocations or meeting times.

In our modern terminology, when Americans hear the word feast, we think of a buffet line. And I have told you what buffet means. Instead of an elaborate meal or banquet, these were special holy convocations or assemblies established by God when the Jews would come together to meet God in a special way. (God wants to meet man in a special way) They were religious gatherings. In a sense, Sunday services are a type of religious feasts of the New Testament church.

God established 7 feasts and scheduled them on the Hebrew calendar in such a way the Jews would have to travel to Jerusalem three times per year to keep them.

There were three feasts seasons.

PASSOVER.

PENTECOST.

TABERNACLES.

These Three feasts seasons represented three major encounters with God in the lives of His covenant people. These three encounters were for the purpose of God providing them with His divine PEACE, POWER AND REST for their lives.

The first feast was PASSOVER. It included, FEASTS OF PASSOVER, UNLEAVEN BREAD, and FIRST FRUITS.

The next feast was PENTECOST. It was a single feast which taught the Jews how to receive the POWER of GOD!

The Third Feast was TABERNACLES. The purpose of this feast was to show God's people how to enter God's rest. It included the FEAST of TRUMPETS, ATONEMENT, and TABERNACLES.

But these feasts or meetings were for the sole design of teaching HIS people how to enter his PEACE, POWER, and REST.

And my aim is to show you that God has not done away with these measures. He still wants you to enter **HIS PEACE, POWER, and REST!**

A child is taught in early grammar school the visual aids of blocks of their ABC's. They are taught to associate the blocks with letters, and then they begin to put them together and learn their ABC's.

God was using these meetings, feasts, as **VISUAL AIDS** to show HIS people how to enter the **PEACE, POWER, and REST** he had for them.

Taken as a whole, these feasts of Jehovah form a complete ***visual aid*** of the person and work of **JESUS CHRIST**, and the steps one must take to walk in the **peace, power and rest of God**.

Scope- *The world today is no different. They have no peace, power or rest. Nations are in a constant search for these attributes to help them, although they are searching in the wrong areas.*

Illus.-A true story: A retired couple was alarmed by the threat of nuclear war so they undertook a serious study of all the inhabited places on the globe. Their goal was to determine where in the world would be the place to be least likely affected by a nuclear war. A place of ultimate security. They studied and traveled, traveled and studied. Finally they found the place. And on Christmas they sent their pastor a card from their new home--in the Falkland Islands. However, their "paradise" was soon turned into a war zone by Great Britain and Argentina.

Jesus said, "Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you. Not as the world gives do I give to you. Let not your hearts be troubled, neither let them be afraid."

--James S. Hewett,

Man is hopelessly enslaved to his own self-destructive habits.

Not every Christian is walking in the power of God. Many are in bondage although they are saved. Many are still overcome by sin, Satan and the fear of death.

We are about to take a journey into the plan of God for the ages and see the way all of us can enter the peace and power and rest of God for our lives.

Much of what I have said and especially the scripture texts seems as mundane. One just reading through chapter 23 of Leviticus may overlook the dates and times and seasons, but they are very important to note and consider.

Jewish calendar- It is very important to see that these feasts were on the Jewish calendar, not the Gregorian calendar. Our calendar is based on the earth rotating around the sun. The days begin at midnight, and last 24 hours. It takes approx. 365 and one quarter days for the earth to make a complete circle around the sun. This determines the length of the year. Some adjustments must be made to make up for the one quarter of a day. This is why an extra day is added every four years making a leap year of 366 days.

THE IMPORTANCE OF THE UNDERSTANDING OF THE JEWISH calendar is because these feasts were based on their calendar not ours.

The Jewish calendar is based on the movement of the moon around the earth. The day begins at sundown (APPROX. 6 PM) lasts for 24 hours. It takes 29 and a half days for the moon to circle the earth. Twelve of these LUNAR months add up to about 354 days for the year. Our calendar is about 11 and one quarter days longer than theirs. There are many other variables to long to mention. But it is important to get these straight in our minds to see how God wanted things to be.

I. Passover!

Passover was celebrated in the month Nisan (March- April) and was the first feast. During this feast, we will discover 7 steps to a Christian's maturity and God's rest.

A) Passover was a memorial of the Hebrews deliverance from Egypt.

It represented God's first encounter with his people.

Egypt had enslaved the Hebrews for about 400 years. God sent Moses as His instrument to lead the Hebrews out of Egypt. God sent 10 horrible plagues on Egypt to convince Pharaoh to let the Hebrews go. Yet each time God sent a plague, Pharaoh's heart was hardened.

On the tenth and final plague, was to be the death of every firstborn of Egypt. But with this special decree of death came special instructions for the Lord about how to be saved from the death angel that was going to go through the land and destroy all the first born. This is how the Passover got its name.

1. Every man was to select for his household a lamb without spot or blemish. He had to select this lamb on THE TENTH DAY of the month! The he was to observe the lamb for FIVE DAYS to make sure there was nothing wrong with him. There could be nothing physically defective about the lamb.
2. On the FIFTH DAY, he brought that lamb to the doorstep of his house and killed him. As he killed the animal, he would take the blood of that lamb and catch it in a basin at the foot of the doorstep. Then he would take that blood and sprinkle it on both sides of the door, and above the doorpost. This showed the entire house was saved from the death angel. It was to be done on the evening of the 14th (twilight) (6PM). Hebrews were to kill the lamb at 3PM, so they could eat the lamb by 6PM. At 3PM, they would kill the lamb, apply the blood, and enter the door of the house where they would eat a meal and be protected from the plague of death that was to move through the land.
3. Although once they entered that door and could not see the blood, they had faith that the blood was to keep them from dying.
4. While inside that night, they ate the lamb, and the angel of death passed through the land killing all firstborn. But when he saw the blood, he could not enter there.
5. When the temple was constructed, the people would bring their lambs to the priest in Jerusalem. They would kill them at the temple instead of at their doorpost.
6. The Passover became a time of festive celebration. They would sing Psalms 113-118 as they sacrificed.
7. As time passed, people in the outlying areas had a difficult time bringing their sacrifices to the temple area. So the Levites began to raise the lambs for the Passover and would sell them at the temple.
8. When the Hebrews would come to Jerusalem, they could purchase a lamb that had already been inspected.

B) How Jesus fulfilled the feast.

1. For 1500 years they had been celebrating the Passover. They knew about lambs. They knew about requirements. The blood would cover their sins but never take them away. Isaiah 53 tells of the lamb that would take the place of the lamb at Passover. Jesus' entire life was predestined to fulfill

this purpose exactly as God had designed it for 1500 years in keeping of the Passover.

2. Note the further comparisons of the feast of the Passover and Jesus.
 - Passover lambs were set aside on 10th day of Nisan.
 - Jesus entered Jerusalem on the 10th day of Nisan to be set aside as the human lamb.

In John 12:1, we find where Jesus came to Bethany 6 days before the feast of Passover.

He came to this city on the 9th day.

Then on the 10th day, Jesus rode into Jerusalem on the donkey the same day

Hebrews would bring their lambs into the city.

Remembered, for 5 days they had to observe the lamb to make sure he was spotless and without defect. Likewise, after Jesus entered the city for 5 days he was observed and tested by the religious leaders. They questioned his AUTHORITY. They asked him trick questions hoping he would somehow give them a wrong answer. They did everything they could to point an accusing finger at him to discredit him. Even Pilate said in John 19:4 that he found in him no fault at all.

IT ALL HAPPENED IN A FIVE DAY PERIOD FROM THE 10TH TO THE 14TH.

AND ON THE 14TH, JESUS WAS CRUCIFIED. HE WAS NOT ONLY CRUCIFIED ON THE SAME DAY THE OTHER LAMBS WERE KILLED BUT AT THE SAME HOUR AS WELL.

- He was crucified at 9 AM on a Wednesday. This was the exact time the Jews were preparing their lambs for Passover. This fulfilled the scripture of Isaiah when he said he bore our grief's and sorrows.
- At 3PM when the lambs were being killed, Jesus died. Mark was careful to note that he breathed his last at the ninth hour. (mark 15:33-37)
- In the instructions of the Passover, the lamb had to be consumed before the day. Jesus was taken down hurriedly before 6PM by request of the Jews. **John 19**

³¹ The Jews therefore, because it was the preparation, that the bodies should not remain upon the cross on the sabbath day, (for that sabbath day was an high day,) besought Pilate that their legs might be broken, and that they might be taken away. **1 Corinthians 5**

⁷ Purge out therefore the old leaven, that ye may be a new lump, as ye are unleavened. For even Christ our Passover is sacrificed for us:

The blood sign was the visual aid God gave his people to learn how to enter the peace of God. (PETER 1:18-21)

1 Peter 1

¹⁸ Forasmuch as ye know that ye were not redeemed with corruptible things, as silver and gold, from your vain conversation received by tradition from your fathers;

¹⁹ But with the precious blood of Christ, as of a lamb without blemish and without spot:

²⁰ Who verily was foreordained before the foundation of the world, but was manifest in these last times for you,

²¹ Who by him do believe in God, that raised him up from the dead, and gave him glory; that your faith and hope might be in God.

C) How this applies personally to us.

1. All of us are without peace. We have all sinned and fallen short of the glory of God. As in Egypt, the angel of death is knocking at our door. Hebrews tells us (2:14-15) **Hebrews 2**
¹⁴ Forasmuch then as the children are partakers of flesh and blood, he also himself likewise took part of the same; that through death he might destroy him that had the power of death, that is, the devil;
¹⁵ And deliver them who through fear of death were all their lifetime subject to bondage. that Satan has a great hold on humanity with the fear of death. Death is one subject we avoid or are afraid of.
2. We are not just afraid of death but what lies beyond death. We are afraid of God. It's because we know down deep inside our sins are separating us from him. We know if God wanted to he would be just in punishing us. Although we try to hide behind the walls of human sufficiency of fame and money and power, we know we are helpless in our fear. Isaiah 48:2 says there is no peace for the wicked.
3. And although we deserve death, God's love has provided a way for us to be saved. When we apply the blood of Jesus to the door of our hearts, we will be saved.
4. We also will run to God instead of fear him. The result of our coming to Christ is PEACE WITH GOD!

The First encounter man will ever have with God is when he accepted God's perfect lamb, Jesus Christ.

5. How we find peace with God is when we accept Christ and FIND PEACE WITH GOD!

Romans 5

¹ Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ:

⁸ But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

⁹ Much more then, being now justified by his blood, we shall be saved from wrath through him.

6. The feast of the Passover symbolized that we have peace with God.
7. Also it is important to note that no un-circumcised person could participate in the Passover. Circumcision was the outward sign of the blood covenant.
8. When we become God's children through the new birth, we have the circumcision of the heart. **Romans 2**
²⁸ For he is not a Jew, which is one outwardly; neither is that circumcision, which is outward in the flesh:
²⁹ But he is a Jew, which is one inwardly; and circumcision is that of the heart, in the spirit, and not in the letter; whose praise is not of men, but of God.

Illus.-A friend visited an elderly woman badly crippled by arthritis. When asked, "Do you suffer much?" she responded, "Yes, but there is no nail here," and she pointed

to her hand. "He had the nails, I have the peace." She pointed to her head. "There are no thorns here. He had the thorns, I have the peace." She touched her side. "There is no spear here. He had the spear, I have the peace." That is what the atonement of Jesus Christ means for us--He gave of himself so that we might have the peace.

Ralph Turnbull, If I Only Had One Sermon to Preach

--James S. Hewett, Illustrations Unlimited

Conclusion- If you are not at peace with God, you can be. You must accept JESUS as the perfect lamb. Become his and find peace that you need so much.